



CRACKDOWN PFI leaders being produced in court after the Sept. 22 raids

A TASTE FOR VIOLENCE

The PFI's violent activities first came to light in 2010 when some of its members chopped off the hands of T.J. Joseph, a Malayalam professor at Newman College, Thodupuzha, for a perceived insult of Prophet Mohammed in an internal question paper that he had set. In 2015, a Kerala court found 13 PFI activists guilty of the crime.

Two years later, in an affidavit in the Kerala High Court, the state government claimed that PFI members were involved in 27 murder cases, 86 attempt-to-murder cases and over 125 cases of creating communal unrest. Data NIA shared reveal that it has convicted 46 PFI men, and charge-sheeted 355. The organisation has also been accused of providing material and physical support to the anti-Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) protests across India in 2019-20 and the farmers' agitation in 2020-2021. Its alleged role in the Northeast Delhi riots in 2020 is also under the scanner.

In 2021, it made news in Assam as the outfit was suspected to be behind the violence in Darrang district during an eviction drive against encroachers. Recently, Assam Police claimed a link between the PFI and the Bangladesh-based Islamic terror group, Ansarullah Bangla Team (ABT). Another 'global link' was the bomb attack on a gurudwara in Kabul, Afghanistan, in March 2020, which killed 25 people—one of the bombers was allegedly a PFI member from Kerala. The central government notification also claims that the PFI has links with the Jamaat-ul-Mujahideen Bangladesh (JMB), and the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS).

The outfit again made the headlines during the hijab row earlier this year, with the Karnataka government telling the Supreme Court that students who had challenged the hijab ban in government institutions had been influenced by the radical outfit. In investigations into the Udaipur killing of tailor Kanhaiya Lal in June—he had supported BJP leader Nupur Sharma, who had made an objectionable comment about the Prophet—the NIA claimed yet again that the accused had links with the PFI.

Two months later, three alleged PFI members were arrested in the Phulwari Sharif area in Patna, with the Bihar police claiming an eight-page document was found on them which put forward a plan to "establish rule of Islam in India by 2047". The NIA is probing this case too.

The PFI has refuted the allegations levelled by investigation agencies and its critics. As the outfit does not keep a record of members, the connections to those found guilty of violence are at best tenuous. Social scientists also hesitate to declare it a terrorist organisation. "It's true that the PFI was a highly radical indigenous organisation. However, their mode of mobilisation was very different from terrorist outfits," says Hilal Ahmed, associate professor, Centre for the Study of Developing Societies (CSDS). Organisations such as the Rajasthan Muslim Forum have also called the arrests and subsequent ban politically motivated.

THE ORIGINS OF PFI

Registered in Delhi under the Societies Registration Act XXI of 1860, PFI's roots can be traced to the National Development Front (NDF), an organisation set up in Kerala in 1994. While the NDF did gain some popularity, it was soon implicated in several incidents of communal violence, including retaliatory strikes where eight Hindus were killed in the Marad beach area in Kozhikode in May 2002. Increasingly under police scrutiny,